

## **Grant Narrative**

### **Purpose and Objectives:**

This proposal envisions a Delaware where civic education doesn't just teach democracy, but also empowers students, families, and communities to actively practice leadership, help influence decisions, and strengthen democratic participation through real world action. The vision has multiple key ideas: active democratic participation (from civic learning to civic power) by analyzing real issues, organizing collectively, engage decision makers, practice advocacy, and educate others. It sees Delaware having a coherent statewide civics strategy where Local Education Agencies (LEA's) adapt and implement strong expectations, all communities are included, and schools receive training and support. It emphasizes students and families having real power rather than symbolic engagement by empowering them to be decision makers and co-creators. This would be through participatory budgeting, school governance roles, and structured feedback systems.

The proposal also envisions hands-on civic practice in schools to practice democracy on a daily basis. This includes community mapping, policy simulations, assemblies, workshops etc. What sets this proposal apart and makes it unique is the emphasis on strategic nonviolence and leadership. It teaches students collective action, strategic nonviolence, dialogue, and conflict navigation which leads to constructive ethical leadership. It is crucial that communities can participate safely, hence the vitality of this proposal being accessible for all communities is emphasized. This includes immigrant

families, black and brown communities, disabled individuals, LGBTQIA individuals, multilingual communities, and faith/diaspora groups. This will turn Delaware Civic Education into a leadership building system where all communities will be empowered to participate and shape our democracy. To expand this framework even more, the idea of a Civics Hub is introduced.

### **Program Description:**

The Civics Hub Concept consists of the following: a community centered space for civic learning, support, and empowerment. The Civics Hub is envisioned as a safe, inclusive, community-oriented space where individuals, especially marginalized communities, can access resources needed for wellbeing and the tools needed to safely participate in democracy. It would serve as a resource center and a civic empowerment space combined. The Civics Hub vision is to ensure a space for building civic knowledge, meeting basic needs, developing leadership skills, access services and opportunities, and engaging in shaping decisions that will affect their lives. This Hub would prioritize communities that face obstacles toward civic participation such as unhoused individuals, low-income families, immigrant communities, disabled individuals, LGBTQIA individuals, etc.

One of the core components of this hub would be to provide accessible tools and workshops on understanding rights and responsibilities, voter registration, policy literacy, community organizing, leadership development, and strategic nonviolence. This could include classes, workshops, and digital resources to ensure a broad audience. Another

core component would be to support basic needs and provide individuals with hygiene kits, meal access, clothing, and transportation assistance. Another core component is wellness access where the hub could build coalitions with health clinics for screenings, mental health support, reproductive health resources, and referrals to clinics. Physically, it could serve as a community space for dialogue, meetings, support groups, workshops, and community events. The place would be accessible, safe, multilingual, and provide assistance for disabled individuals. Since many marginalized communities also face barriers to technology access, this Hub could provide free Wi-Fi, access to computers, and digital literacy training.

### **Significance:**

The significance of the Civics Hub and expanding civic education framework is to recognize that particularly for marginalized individuals, barriers such as poverty, housing instability, disability, language access, discrimination, and limited trust make civic engagement difficult. Traditional civic education makes the assumption that everyone has access to resources provided when every individual has a different situation that may pose a barrier to engagement. This framework is vital because it redefines civic education as a participatory process. It does not limit civic education to classes but rather expands it to communities to address systemic barriers that may prevent participation. The Civics Hub adds to this proposal by providing a physical location that supports empowerment. It combines basic needs, technology & healthcare support, and resources for civic education and leadership development to ensure sustained engagement that is supported.

This framework is also significant because it centers around empowering and including marginalized communities in participatory civic education rather than as a symbolic component. It frames them as leaders and co-creators of expansion in their communities. When marginalized individuals are included in civic education it directly correlates to higher percentages of civic engagement in the community. On a larger scale this proposal contributes to democratic resilience. During this time of intense political polarization, and declining trust in institutions, it is essential to build civic power. This framework strengthens critical thinking, dialogue, community organizing, leadership, and strategic nonviolence. Ultimately, the main goal is to move from civic awareness to civic empowerment. This idea offers a sustainable model for participatory civic culture to include all voices, and possibly opens up the doors for expansion and replication in other cities.

### **Timeline:**

The Civics Hub could launch in multiple phases to ensure that there is no overload:

Phase 1: Workshops, resource distribution, and limited services

Phase 2: Coalition Building (schools, non-profits, clinics, shelters)

Phase 3: Full Civics Hub model at a permanent location with all services and resources

Phase 4: Possible replication to other Delaware Cities

## **Projected Outcomes:**

This Hub and expansion framework ensure that communities are empowered to shape the system that affects their lives. Another important outcome is the increase in Civic Engagement in Delaware communities. This will be seen as there will be greater participation in schools, communities, and local government and an increased willingness to participate in collective action and dialogue. Another outcome will be the development of civic capacities which includes critical thinking skills, leadership skills, digital literacy skills, and coalition building which allows participants to be able to adapt their civic engagement. An additional critical outcome is collective power and increased community connections as relationships can form between youth, families, and community members, as there are shared spaces for dialogue and organizing. Perhaps the most important outcome will be the increased accessibility to civic engagement/participation for marginalized groups as access to basic needs, technology, and safe participation will reduce barriers that traditionally prevented underrepresented groups from engaging in civics.

While there are several outcomes that could arise from this project there are also some possible challenges. Potential challenges include: funding and sustainability, trained staffing, location, and maintaining safety and trust. In regard to funding and sustainability, a partnership between schools, non-profits, healthcare, and local institutions would allow for shared resources and a more evenly divided funding process. A permanent location in a community with large numbers of marginalized groups would have to be found and staff

would have to go through extensive training to ensure a smooth process. Very importantly to maintain safety and trust there could be multiple pathways to participation to ensure engagement without risk of exposure for individuals who might be fearful. These pathways include multilingual access, a design that is safely conscious, and a possible digital forum for discussion. Together, expanding civic education framework and the development of a Civics Hub could be an ideal model for increased civic education and participation as it addresses systemic barriers.

**Staffing:**

To ensure implementation and coordination of this expansion framework through the Civics Hub a dedicated Project Coordinator role is vital. This role would be responsible for organizing workshops, managing partnerships/coalitions with community organizations, coordinating the distribution of resources, and outreach to marginalized communities. Due to the broad scope of responsibilities and consistent work, a project-based stipend between \$10,000-\$15,000 is proposed. This reflects a realistic rate for community based civic engagement and being able to successfully implement this project.

**Proposed Budget:**

| <b>Category</b> | <b>Item</b>                  | <b>Description</b>                                                                    | <b>Estimated Cost (USD)</b> |
|-----------------|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Personnel       | Project Coordinator          | Project coordination, leadership, outreach, coalitions, and management                | \$10,000-\$15,000           |
| Personnel       | Workshop Facilitators        | Guest speakers and community experts (\$200-\$300/session)                            | \$2,000-\$3,000             |
| Personnel       | Community Support Staff      | Part-time staff trained in civic education, strategic nonviolence, and best practices | \$4,000-\$7,000             |
| Hub Costs       | Workshop Materials           | Materials, supplies, and educational tools                                            | \$1,000-\$2,000             |
| Hub Costs       | Basic Needs Materials        | Hygiene kits, meals, transportation assistance                                        | \$3,000-\$5,000             |
| Space Costs     | Space rental and event costs | Physical space for events and workshops                                               | \$5,000-\$10,000            |
| Partnerships    | Coalitions                   | Partnerships with clinics, non-profits, organizations                                 | \$3,000-\$5,000             |
| Technology      | Equipment                    | Computers, WIFI, digital literacy tools                                               | \$5,000-\$6,000             |
| Technology      | Language Access              | Translation services, multilingual materials & tools, accessibility tech              | \$4,000-\$6,000             |
| Other           | Extra                        | Extra emergency funds                                                                 | \$1,000-\$2,000             |

## References Cited

Beauchamp Pagan, M. (2025). *From Civic Learning to Civic Power*.